

Alpha Monocerotis
48 Suns

Delta Monocerotis
265 Suns

Gamma Monocerotis
515 Suns

MONOCEROS

THE UNICORN

A LARGE BUT NOT PROMINENT CONSTELLATION, MONOCEROS HAS NO BRIGHT INDIVIDUAL STARS. HOWEVER, IT DOES CONTAIN MANY NOTABLE MULTIPLE STARS AND DEEP-SKY OBJECTS, SUCH AS STAR CLUSTERS AND NEBULAE.

Monoceros is situated between Hydra and Orion, with Canis Major to the south and Canis Minor to the north. Beta Monocerotis is one of the finest triples in the sky. Its three 5th-magnitude stars can be separated with small telescopes. Delta Monocerotis is a wide, unrelated pair of stars, visible with binoculars. Epsilon Monocerotis, of 4th magnitude, has a fainter, unrelated companion visible through small telescopes.

Lying in the band of the Milky Way, Monoceros has many star clusters and nebulae. Among the features visible with binoculars are the open cluster M50 in the south of the constellation, and NGC 2264 in the north. Long-exposure images show a faint nebulosity around NGC 2264, including a dark dust lane, the Cone Nebula. Another notable deep-sky object is the Rosette Nebula, surrounding the elongated star cluster NGC 2244.

Delta (δ) Monocerotis

This 4th-magnitude star has an unrelated companion, called 21 Monocerotis. The companion star is closer to us than Delta Monocerotis and is visible with binoculars or even sharp eyesight

M50
An open cluster visible through binoculars, M50 lies about 3,000 light-years away. A telescope is needed to resolve its individual stars, which are of 8th magnitude and fainter

NGC 2264

This open cluster, about 2,500 light-years away, can be observed with binoculars. Through a small telescope it looks triangular in shape. Its brightest member is the 5th-magnitude star S Monocerotis

NGC 2244

At the core of the Rosette Nebula, about 5,500 light-years away, is this elongated star cluster, which is visible through binoculars. The Rosette Nebula itself (NGC 2237) is three to four times larger than NGC 2244

NGC 2232

Visible through binoculars, this scattered cluster is about 1,300 light-years from Earth. Its brightest member is the 5th-magnitude star 10 Monocerotis

